

One More Time Around

After the stress and excitement of Danni's match with Fox, the rest of the semi-final round was almost an afterthought for me.

That changed pretty fast when the results started rolling in, though.

Middleweight: Sometimes, it's just not meant to be. It's not that Britney wasn't excellent. Defense, timing, strategy... it was all there. Josie Maran was just better.

To a degree, it was surprising. After all, only one week earlier, Josie had achieved what had previously seemed impossible. For the first time ever, she had beaten the practically unbeatable Doutzen Kroes. In many respects, it was the single greatest accomplishment any middleweight in the league could hope for. Probably even greater than winning a tournament title. So conventional wisdom said Josie was primed for an emotional letdown against Brit.

But it was only surprising if you bought into stuff like that, which I do not. Trap fights and emotional letdowns are just excuses. I put my faith in preparation - both physical and mental. If you want to win, you'll be ready... and Josie was. Physically, Maran was on top of her game. Mentally... well, I would say her confidence was pretty high. I mean, she'd just beaten Doutzen Kroes... and if you could beat Doutzen, then who COULDN'T you beat?

That was the story in this one. Both fighters put on a great performance, but Josie wasn't going to be denied. With Kroes out of the picture, the path was clear for her to take the title home. She wasn't going to let Britney get in the way.

Meanwhile, in the bottom-half of the bracket, Jennifer Lawrence looked sensational in winning the war of the double-digits - dominating Mischa Barton over nearly two rounds of action before scoring the knockout just before the second break.

The question now was, could J-Law stop Maran's seemingly inevitable victory and grab the title for herself?

From where I was sitting, I thought she had a pretty tall hill to climb. I couldn't count her out. She'd simply been too good for that. But Josie? After big wins over Jen Stano, Doutzen and Britney, she just had that look of destiny to her.

Light Heavyweight: I've noticed there's an interesting inequity in the way I talk about Daniela Hantuchova when compared to say... Emily VanCamp. Here I have run out of words to describe Em's performances, and Daniela gets, *Hmm? Oh, yeah... she won again. Crazy, right?*

I think the key difference is the way we here at RSI have come to know each of them. We watched Emily grow and develop into her role as a superstar. We witnessed her struggles and triumphs along the way. Daniela came in the door with the belt slung over her shoulder, and all she's done since then is win. She

once had two fights in a row where it took her more than one round to get the win and defend her title. That qualifies as struggle in the world of Daniela Hantuchova.

Here's the thing: Daniela's semi-final opponent, Brooklyn Decker, is a tough, smart, skilled fighter. I don't need to do a lot of research to prove that out. I can just ask Aly Michalka. She and Decker have met more times than I care to count, and Aly has only come out on top once. Brooklyn is a nightmare for her. An absolute nightmare.

But Daniela?

The fight lasted two minutes and forty-five seconds. From the very start, Brooklyn seemed determined to take the action to the mat. Unlike what Danni faced in Megan Fox, this was something of a surprise. Brooklyn is capable on the ground, but she is much better standing up. Takedowns are really not part of her game. Why the switch? Well, I can only guess Decker and her team decided not to face Daniela head-on, and it's kind of hard to fault them on that. Hantuchova has always been great, but she'd been a one woman wrecking crew so far in this tournament. Those who stood in front of her tended to fall down... hard and fast. So, it made perfect sense for Brooklyn to want to try something different.

That said, maybe she should have tried something else.

First off, Decker was having trouble even getting the strategy off the ground. Or, more accurately, she couldn't get it to the ground. She tried shooting in. She tried sweeps. She tried everything. Nothing she did seemed to faze Daniela. She just wasn't as explosive as someone like Fox was, and Daniela was able to react and counter and stay on her feet. After a minute or so, Brooklyn got a little frustrated. When her next attempt also failed, she decided on a less artistic approach. Call it the sloppy takedown, if you will. The two fighters grappled and wrestled as they fought for position. Daniela wanted to get her hands free and throw punches. Brooklyn wanted to keep those hands under control as she tried in vain to trip the Slovakian fighter up. They pushed and shoved for a while until Brooklyn finally just said the hell with it and steamrolled her opponent. Daniela lost her balance and fell. Success? Hardly. A relatively soft landing left Hantuchova in excellent defensive position. Decker tried to force it, and ended up caught in Daniela's guard.

A minute and a half gone. The fight was on the canvas and Decker was on top, but it wasn't really what she wanted. Five seconds later, it wasn't anything close to what she wanted.

With Brooklyn firmly ensnared, Daniela rolled them both over. She came up on top and scrambled into mount position with very little effort. Then the punches rained down. One, two, three... Decker got the hands tied up and the action paused. A little hand grappling, then Daniela pulled her right free. The punches came again. Four of them this time. Brooklyn regained some control, but only for a moment. The punches resumed.

It went like that for nearly a full minute. Decker would get mercilessly pounded for a few seconds, then tie things up. Daniela would patiently grind and maneuver to get a hand free, then drop the hammer once again. She was ruthless. Punches and elbows rained down in bunches. By the time Brooklyn tied things up for good, she was a blood soaked mess.

Still... only thirty seconds to go. There was every chance the American would hang on. She just needed to stay away... but Daniela didn't allow it. She pressured and chased. Decker quickly realized she would have to stand and fight. As soon as she set her feet, Daniela knew. Like she had simply been waiting on the inevitable. Brooklyn moved forward to attack. Daniela took a big step across her own body. She planted her foot, her hips rotated and she spun like a coiled spring coming unwound.

Spinning backfist. The same move Jennifer Walcott had tried and missed against Liv. But Decker was beaten and hurt. If she understood what was happening, she gave no sign. Then Daniela's fist cracked into her skull, and Brooklyn no longer gave any sign of being conscious, either.

In two minutes and forty-five seconds, Daniela had not just won, but had literally pounded Decker into oblivion. When the blonde refused to go toe-to-toe, Daniela adapted and beat her senseless anyway. Like it just didn't matter.

Go ahead and pick your poison, Brooklyn. Any way you choose, you're dead meat.

But that's the thing about Daniela. She never said anything like that. Never even hinted she was thinking it. She just went out there and did it. Same as always.

Just another day at the beach for Daniela Hantuchova.

Heavyweight: When last we left her, Dianna Dahlgren had scored an unbelievable victory over defending tournament champion Samantha Hoopes. Now the question was, did the sixteenth-seeded dynamo have anything left for five seed Traci Bingham?

Yep. She had plenty.

Bingham tried to slow things down early by taking the action to the mat. That's not Dianna's favorite place to be, but she proved up to the task as she held the SCQ fighter off long enough for referee Fearne Cotton to intervene. Not much damage done, but had Bingham managed to take the starch out of the RSI fighter? Hardly. Once the women were back on their feet, Dianna picked up right where she'd left off against Hoopes... punishing her opponent with hard, precise strikes that beat Bingham's defense on a consistent basis. Several times, it looked like Cotton might have to stop it, but the ref stayed out of it and let the older fighter survive until the break. A narrow escape, but she would have a lot of work to do if she was going to come back. And only a few seconds had ticked off in the second before it became obvious that wasn't going to happen. Bingham was hurt, and she wasn't defending herself at all. Still Cotton chose not to get involved. Dianna continued to do what she was trained to do, carefully stalking her opponent while working to finish the job. But Bingham refused to go down and Cotton still refused to stop it. The result? Bingham suffered a broken cheekbone. A terrible injury that simply didn't have to happen.

The injury was upsetting and Cotton's inaction was totally inexcusable, but none of that did anything to diminish what Dianna had done. Two momentous and resounding victories had her headed for her first ever tournament final.

Meanwhile, the other half of the bracket had lined up a war between the quiet, confident and deadly Catherine Bell, and the phenomenally talented and accomplished Caroline Wozniacki. The woman who had taught Samantha Hoopes how to be the destructive force she was.

I don't think I have to spend much time explaining how much excitement this matchup generated. Both Mac and Woz have proven in the past how good they can be. They've trained together. They know each other. So the expectations headed into this fight were enormous.

The ladies did not disappoint.

The first round was, in a word, epic. Fists flew. Blood spilled. The action was intense as control seesawed back and forth. It was everything the fans could ask for, and the two warriors seemed to be enjoying themselves, too. If there was anything to complain about, it was that the battle was too short. Near the end of the round, Cat let loose with a wild roundhouse that caught Wozniacki napping. With the Dragon fighter stunned, Bell pressed forward for the finish. Crushing shots landed from every direction as the tennis star tried to cover up. She somehow managed to last until the bell, but the damage was done. The break wasn't enough for the young champion to recover, and Cat finished the job quickly in the second.

So, the final was set. Teammate versus teammate. The established veteran against the upstart youngster.

Oh, and just a little side note... with both finalists coming out of the RSI camp, we now had at least one title in the bag.

Super Heavyweight: I love that RSI has so many title-worthy competitors, but son of a bitch... why do they have to keep running into each other? The only positive I can offer about the semi-final showdown between Torrie and Steph is that it was mercifully quick, with Torrie landing the knockout blow just over two minutes into the first round. Truth is - though I hate to see any of my fighters crumpled on the canvas - this was just one of those things. Steph took a shot and missed, and Torrie's counter landed right on the button. Cringe-worthy, but it spared me yet another long ordeal, so I'll take it. The downside was that Torrie was now headed for one hell of a showdown, as she and second-seeded Maria Sharapova were the only one-two pairing to survive into the final round.

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And so the championship round was set, and with it came a few notable technical changes. The first was that the fights would be expanded to five rounds instead of the three that had been the norm for the tournament thus far. It was easy to understand why the league wanted this. These were the big fights. The ones for all the marbles. Lengthening them to five rounds made them feel like something special. It was also stupid. The three round benchmark had been established because of the grueling, compact schedule. So now, at the very end, they were going to make the fighters go two additional rounds? What the hell sense did that make?

Ah, but wait... the league wasn't done. Because two extra rounds apparently wasn't special enough, they also decided to restore the rounds to the standard five-minute length.

Again, if you squinted, you could find some sense in all this. After all, the league standard for championship bouts was five, five-minute rounds, and that's what these were.

The truth was that it was just more counterproductive nonsense. They were running the risk of having these matchups ruined by injury and fatigue in an attempt to create drama where none was needed.

The final change was the only one that made any real sense because it was squarely focused on the only thing that mattered. The quality of the fights, themselves. The nature of a tournament like this is that the fighters left standing at the end were supposed to be the best of the best. Indeed, most of the finalists here had already proven themselves elite in the past. Having them all in action on the same night was a rare and valuable opportunity. So, the final round would not happen in weight class order the way all the others had. Instead, the order would be set by perceived interest and quality. All of these fights were going to pull in viewers, but some had all the right ingredients to become legendary battles. Some were showdowns the fans had long been dying to see. Others represented yet another chapter in some of the most storied rivalries. So the idea was to try and figure out which ones had the most potential to become classics and have the schedule build to a crescendo.

Did they get it right? That depends on how you look at it. No doubt, some of the early fights were going to be surprise classics, while some of the later ones would not measure up to the hype. But hype was all they had to go on and, from that perspective, I think they did pretty well.

Bantamweight

(15) Jennifer Morrison vs (1) Keira Knightley

Middleweight

(10) Jennifer Lawrence vs (8) Josie Maran

Heavyweight

(2) Catherine Bell vs (16) Dianna Dahlgren

Light Heavyweight

(2) Daniela Hantuchova vs (5) Amber Heard

Super Heavyweight

(1) Torrie Wilson vs (2) Maria Sharapova

Lightweight

(1) Emily VanCamp vs (3) Ali Larter

Featherweight

(4) Emma Watson vs (3) Nadine Coyle

Welterweight

(1) Dannel Harris vs (3) Cheryl Cole

Meanwhile... when the semi-final battles were over and the blood and sweat had been mopped out of the cage, we at RSI discovered a remarkable thing had happened. We didn't stop at those four finalists I'd been

hoping for, or even at our previous record of six. We got nine. One week from now, all eight titles would be decided. One was a sure thing, and we had a damn good shot at the other seven.

By any measure, it was mind-blowing, and it made us the talk of the league. RSI-mania - which had never really existed before - was suddenly at a fever pitch. But the truth is, it meant little in the grander scheme. People would only remember what we'd done here if we brought home some hardware. We had never won more than two titles in any previous tournament. With expectations so high, we would have to do better than that here.

A tall order in a league with this much talent. But after the show we'd already put on, who would bet against us?